Week 18: New Testament Letters (Literary Context)

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

New Testament letters are carefully composed, not just casual mail — tonight we'll look at how they're actually put together.

1. Think of a well-organized speech, sermon, or argument you've heard that really stuck with you. What made it easy to follow — a clear structure, a repeated phrase, a turning point you could feel coming?

2. **Read Romans 1:1-6.** What does Paul call himself in verse 1, and what does he say about who Jesus is and what he's called Paul to do? What does it tell you that Paul uses even the "opening address" to set the tone and themes for the entire letter?

3. **Read Romans 1:8-10.** What does Paul say he thanks God for, and what does he say he constantly does in his prayers for them (vv. 8-10)? Ancient letters often opened with a prayer of thanks to the gods for the recipient's wellbeing, and Paul follows that convention but makes it his own. What does his thanksgiving here — remembering them "constantly," praying to finally visit — tell you about his relationship with a church he had never even met in person?

4. **Read Romans 12:1-2.** What does Paul urge the Romans to do with their bodies, and what does he say they should not do, but instead be transformed by (vv. 1-2)? Romans 12 opens with "Therefore" — a hinge word connecting eleven chapters of dense argument about God's mercy to a whole new section about how to actually live. Why do you think Paul waits until now, after building his entire theological case, to start telling the Romans how to behave?

5. **Read Romans 12:3-13.** What specific gifts or roles does Paul name in this passage, and what image does he use to describe how they fit together (vv. 4-8)? Tracing the repeated picture of "one body" made of different parts through the paragraph, what is Paul building toward — what does he want this specific church, made up of very different kinds of people, to understand about themselves?

6. **Read Romans 16:17-20.** What does Paul specifically instruct the Romans to do about people who "cause divisions," and what does he promise will happen to Satan (vv. 17, 20)? Given everything Paul has said about unity and love throughout the letter, why end on this particular note instead of a simple farewell?

7. Paul's letters typically ran far longer than the average ancient letter — Romans and 1 Corinthians alone would have cost the equivalent of thousands of dollars to compose and send in the first century. Why do you think Paul was willing to invest that much time, money, and effort into one piece of correspondence?

8. Knowing that these letters were built as single, unified arguments — not loose collections of stand-alone verses — how might that change the way you personally read and quote Scripture going forward?

9. Think of a piece of writing you need to do soon — an email, a hard conversation, a word of encouragement to a friend. What's the one "main idea" you'd want everything else to connect back to, the way Paul's whole letter to Ephesus connects back to his opening prayer?

10. These letters were meant to be read aloud in one sitting to a gathered church, not studied privately verse-by-verse. What might change if you read through an entire New Testament letter aloud, start to finish, with your own group or family — the way its first hearers would have heard it?